

One Choice Changes Everything

# CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work  
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

**DAN DOBOS**

# 6

## Rational Work Only Produces Rational Results

*The unexpected path to extraordinary achievement.*

### How to Receive a Nobel Prize

Richard Feynman was a physicist who, at one point in his career, was in a bit of a slump. He lamented how he used to enjoy physics because he “used to play with it.” Specifically, he recalls how “it didn’t have to do with whether it was important for the development of nuclear physics, but whether it was interesting and amusing for me to play with.”

He used to treasure tinkering with physics, having that lightness in his work. But since his joy had faded, he resolved to stop approaching physics too seriously.

Feynman rediscovered that lost spark while sitting in the cafeteria. He noticed a student fooling around and throwing a plate in the air. He thought about this rotating plate and came up with some ideas about the physics of what was happening.

He approached his colleague Hans and said, “Hey Hans, I noticed something interesting here... The plate goes around...” and showed him the accelerations.

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Hans replied, “Feynman, that’s pretty interesting. But what’s the importance of it? Why are you doing it?”

Feynman responded, “Huh! There’s no importance whatsoever! I’m just doing it for the fun of it!”

That’s a key line: “I’m just doing it for the fun of it.” Feynman continued to work on it and reflected on how there was “no importance to what I was doing, but ultimately there was. The diagrams and the whole business that I got the Nobel Prize for came from that piddling around with the wobbling plate.” This state of playful creativity helps create what the pioneering psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi calls a flow state.

By focusing on playful exploration, Feynman became more creative, which led him to win a Nobel Prize. Similarly, Apple, Google, YouTube, Facebook, Airbnb, WhatsApp, and countless other significant businesses all began as side projects pursued by their founders just for fun.

What do you do purely for fun? Which activities cause you to lose track of time because you are so immersed in them? Imagine doing this work instead of clocking in and clocking out. Imagine having fun all day and receiving the equivalent of a Nobel Prize for your work, just like Feynman did.

### **How to Work Like Richard Feynman**

Do you ever wonder if you’ll hit your targets to keep earning a respectable salary at an established company? That’s a very different approach from the one Feynman adopted. He was less concerned about the outcome and more interested in fully exploring a compelling idea.

Working like Feynman means your focus is on the quality of your work without burdening your mind about the specific outcome it may produce. In this state, you are able to produce your most inspired work, which is usually your best work. But when your work is required to produce a specific outcome, your focus narrows, resulting in work that is more likely to be bland, standardized, and predictable.

## RATIONAL WORK ONLY PRODUCES RATIONAL RESULTS

This effect occurs in many domains. For example, observe how elite athletes — golf players, tennis players, and even chess grandmasters — can choke and surrender a winning advantage by overthinking what they're doing. The desire to win becomes so strong that it distracts them from properly concentrating on what they are doing.

In contrast to being focused on an outcome, consider how you feel when you do work simply because you find it inherently enjoyable. In this state, there is a sense of effortlessness in the actions you take. You get in touch with a deeper form of energy. You start to glide. It's like being a musician in an orchestra, sensing the symphony and playing perfectly in tune. As Feynman said, "It was like uncorking a bottle: Everything flowed out effortlessly."

Take a moment to reconnect with yourself and consider —

*When was the last time you went for a walk in the rain?  
When was the last time you smelled the earthy perfume of the forest?  
When was the last time you took in the golden rays of a sunset?  
When was the last time you experienced a moment that took your  
breath away?  
When was the last time you simply paused to be grateful for all  
you've got?*

Reflect on these moments. Channel this energy into new activities.

*Go to the beach and walk barefoot through the sand.  
Write a heartfelt letter to someone who matters to you.  
Dance to your favorite song with reckless abandon.  
Spend time with people who make you feel truly seen and heard.  
Cook your favorite dish.  
Read a biography of someone you admire.  
Laugh with young children.  
Gaze at the stars.  
Meditate in the silence of the night.  
Listen to the sound of the rain.  
Ponder the infinite size of the universe.*

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Embrace the moments that make you feel fully alive. As you are immersed in one such moment, pause, pinch yourself, and remind yourself that this is living, that this is why you are here. If you do this frequently enough, you will no longer tolerate meaningless activities that rob you of this blissful state.

What if you cannot find this state in your work? What if your occupation only brings you bitterness and angst? In that case, you almost certainly need to start looking for another line of work because your discontent will infect your work and prevent you from realizing your full potential. If you are purely rational at work, you will not produce anything more than rational results. The world deserves more than lifeless inputs. The world wants you to engage your heart. The world wants you to create work with your entire being.

When your work comes from your heart, it will be felt much more deeply than anything logic can produce. Mine your work from the depths of your being, and you will create something far purer and more energized than anything logical thought can output. The degree of emotional commitment you invest in the input will determine the degree of excitement others experience in the output.

For some, the logical path is where they find their flow. Logic is a powerful tool when it brings clarity, structure, and rigor to our thinking. But logic alone can strip away the layers of depth that give life its color and vibrancy. It is blind to the emotional nuances, the spark of creativity, and the intangibles that make a work truly exceptional. Without emotional awareness, logical work can feel sterile and predictable, leading to outcomes that are technically correct yet cold and impersonal. Let's consider some examples that contrast the heart with the logical mind.

Podcasts created with love don't just deliver information; they provide valuable insights. Translations done with love don't merely provide a literal interpretation but instead capture the nuances and emotions of the original text. Legal advice given with love is more than just technically correct; it's supportive and responds to the emotional needs of the client.

Music composed with love travels beyond the ears, all the way to the heart. Events organized with love don't just inform or entertain; they create memories that are treasured forever.

Expressions of the heart always outweigh explanations of the mind because the mysteries of the heart have an inexplicable way of transcending the confines of logic. Work ought to be a structure through which your true self expresses its love. Once you reach this point, you cease working for external validation and begin to do things purely because they are inherently worth doing.

Money will come and go. People will come in and out of your life. Possessions can get lost or stolen. But the experience of creating work from your heart can never be taken away from you.

Think twice before you accept a job that is merely "good enough."

If you work with love, then maybe — just maybe — you may reach the point where your work assumes the character of the Spanish concept of *duende*. This is the unmistakable intense energy you feel radiating from a person who delivers an awe-inspiring performance that baffles rational understanding. Such performances take your breath away, make the hair on the back of your neck stand up, and leave you close to tears. These masters exhibit such high vitality in their work that they often appear much younger than their actual age. The love of their craft seems to rejuvenate their body and mind, causing their biological age to be far lower than their actual age.

It takes time to attain the level of greatness characterized by the concept of *duende*. You don't wake up one day and start juggling seven balls. It takes many years. It takes dedication. If you don't enjoy the process, you have no chance; you're finished before you even take the first step.

Choosing your work doesn't require a performance for a crowd. It doesn't have to be fancy work either. It could be as simple as a love of repairing cars. Or you might love doing math. Or maybe sewing and creating dresses brings you great joy. Or you might love building a team.

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No matter how plain, simple, or ordinary your work may appear on the outside, when you *feel* it deeply, you give it the care and attention it deserves. Your peaceful and gentle breath brings your complete conscientiousness to your work. You discover that your work is inextricably connected to your existence. As your work helps you unravel the mystery of your heart, as you become more whole with your being, you feel more deeply the profound richness of the human experience.

But then someone very rational tells you not to study history because “it won’t be good for your future.” You must reply, “I’m sorry, I love history — it makes my heart sing. There’s nothing in the world I want to do more than study history.”

Or perhaps another lost soul says to you, “Why do you like painting? Why don’t you get a real job?”

This is a question you cannot answer. There simply does not exist any answer to the question, “Why do you love painting or dancing or sewing or math or building a team?” It’s a bit like asking, “Why were you born in your current form and not as a different person?” We don’t know. You just came out the way you did. Similarly, there is no logical reason that can justify what brings you joy. The mysteries of the heart cannot be reduced to any rational explanation. The best you can do is accept it and embrace it. Know this —

*When you love life, you radiate that loving energy onto others.*

*When you feel joy, you radiate that warm joy onto others.*

*When you follow your intuition, you radiate that inner calm onto others.*

*When you live your truth, your presence alone can inspire others to discover their truth.*

When you find this work, you will feel it. It won’t resemble labor at a random job. It’s like watching a sunrise. It’s pure joy. It’s a privilege. It’s an honor to be able to do it every day. It’s a visceral feeling, like you are finally swimming with the current instead of against it. It’s like you’re running with a tailwind propelling you forward instead of a headwind

blowing you backward. Your adapted self disappears because your true self is completely absorbed in what you are doing. In this state, you are so intensely focused that nothing can distract you. You are peaceful. Light. Serene. Time distorts itself and seems to travel much faster than usual. Work seems like play. The creative sparks built into this play produce brilliant results. If your work doesn't feel deeply right, it's probably not the work for you.

It is the pursuit of this feeling, not the “seven strategies for success” nor any hack you read on social media, that will place you on the path to extraordinary success.

### **The Hidden Path to Extraordinary Success**

Winning a Nobel Prize is great. Fame has its benefits. But the true masters escaped the adapted self and were driven by something deeper than trophies or money. They wrote because they had to write. They composed because they had to compose. They were compelled by a feeling they neither understood nor could explain but which they knew was deeply right.

When Phil Ivey won the World Series of Poker, he could have easily taken the huge prize money and celebrated with friends into the night. Instead, he went to his hotel room and reviewed every hand with peers to see where he could improve. When psychologist Daniel Kahneman won the Nobel Prize in economics, he could have basked in the unusual glory of winning a prize outside his own field. Instead, Kahneman invited colleagues to disprove his theories. When Magnus Carlsen played Levon Aronian in the final round of the 2013 Sinquefeld Cup, an elite chess tournament, he could have guaranteed tournament victory by agreeing to the draw offer. Instead, at the risk of losing, Carlsen chose to keep playing and ultimately prevailed to win the game.

Ivey, Kahneman, and Carlsen all embraced the mystery rather than the manifestation. Meaning, they were fascinated with the elegance of their craft, not the prizes of their pursuits. The mark of a champion is



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a humble spirit funneling intensity into the art, into the creation, into getting it right for the sake of getting it right and nothing more. If there is a prize, so be it, but it is never the focus. Meanwhile, the pretender obsesses over the prize, and in doing so, never becomes a champion.

The true masters remain unsatisfied with their results, not because they are ungrateful, but because their devotion to the craft leaves no room for complacency. Until you fall in love with the process, no amount of fame, money, or applause will bring you lasting fulfillment. Recognition without mastery feels hollow.

Are you looking to become a chef so that you can become a famous celebrity? Or do you love cooking and seeing the joy you bring to people when they love your food? Do you want to build a business to gain power and make money, or do you love the challenge of working with a team to solve problems and create something greater than yourself? Do you want to become a scientist to win a Nobel Prize, or like Feynman, do you love the process of discovery?

Extraordinary success rarely comes from merely setting extraordinary goals. Instead, it emerges unexpectedly from acts that bring you extraordinary joy.

Let's use the following reflection to consider how you can bring joy into what you are doing right now.



# The Rational Trap

## 1. *What is the rational work that I do that produces rational results?*

- To identify rational work, list everything that you do, without judging your ideas. Sometimes your best insights come after you've emptied your mind.
- Identify one task you do because it has to be done, not because it energizes you. Which routine tasks feel repetitive or do not help you grow?

## 2. *What is one small step I can take tomorrow to bring more joy into my current work?*

- Brainstorm one small, actionable step you can take tomorrow to add joy and creativity to your work.
- Is there a way to make a task at work more stimulating by making it more challenging?

Notice how the rational work above is different from the playful exploration that led Feynman to a Nobel Prize. Similarly, Apple, Google, YouTube, Facebook, Airbnb, WhatsApp, and countless other major companies were set up as side projects. If you were to engage in playful exploration, what is a side project that you could do?

### **Duration**

Two minutes per question

Feel free to exceed the suggested duration if you wish. This reflection is intentionally brief because small, consistent changes lead to life-changing results.

Write Your Reflections Here

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- ☐ I have identified the rational work that produces rational results.
- ☐ I have found one small step I can take to bring more joy into my current work.

## **In the Next Chapter...**

In this chapter, we looked at how to bring more joy into your work. But how do you know what will bring you the most joy? That's the topic for the next chapter.

# Praise for *Choose Your Work*

*Choose Your Work* is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

**Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators**

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

**Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove**

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

**Teshia Harding**

*Choose Your Work* distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

**Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss***

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

**Kayla Giles**

*Choose Your Work* is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

**Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania**

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

**Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher**

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

**Christy Oshima**

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

**Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University**

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

**James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine**

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**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,  
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?  
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,  
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a  
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,  
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

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How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

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Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

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Why being good at something may lead you down the  
wrong path and how to find the right one

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Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and  
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what  
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

*"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."*

Beau Florenosos

*"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."*

Jean Rose Dogillo

*"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."*

Liz Treat